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Isaiah

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Isaiah

A. Overview and Summary.

1. The book of Isaiah was written by the prophet Isaiah (Vs. 1:1). Reputable Bible teachers agree that there is only one author of Isaiah and that is the prophet Isaiah himself. In the late eighteenth century, some liberal scholars developed what is called the Deutero-Isaiah theory in an attempt to explain the detailed prophecies contained in chapters 40 through 66. They claim that Isaiah wrote only the first 39 chapters and that his disciples wrote 40 through 66 after the prophecies had been fulfilled. They attempt to use some literary style differences of chapters 1-39 compared with 40-66. However, when we look at references to Isaiah in the New Testament, Jesus and the Apostles clearly reference only one Isaiah. For example, in Mark 7:6-7, Jesus mentions Isaiah and quotes from Isaiah 29:13. He also quotes from Isaiah 42:1-4 in Matthew 12:17. John quotes from both sections in John chapter 12:38-40. He quotes from Isaiah 53:1 in John 12:38 and uses the term “For again Isaiah said” to quote from Isaiah 6:9-10 in John 2:39. Additionally, Isaiah uses similar words throughout the book, and he reveals his familiarity with Israel but not with Babylon, where his disciples supposedly wrote the final chapters. Jewish tradition attributes the author to the Prophet Isaiah. The Bible is silent as to Isaiah’s death. Jewish tradition says that he was sawn in half by the evil king Manasseh. This seems to match Hebrews 11:37, where it says some were sawn in two.
2. Acceptance of the Deutero-Isaiah theory has led some believers to doubt the authenticity of Scripture. But for the reasons above, we can clearly affirm that Isaiah wrote the book of Isaiah between 739 and 681 BC. The book can logically be divided into those same two sections. The first 39 chapters deal primarily with Isaiah’s prophecy and admonition to Judah calling for her repentance from sin and idolatry. God is Holy (Isaiah 6:3) and cannot let sin go unpunished. His judgement is portrayed as a devouring fire (Vs. 30:30). The nations of Assyria and Babylon will be used as tools of His judgement. But chapters 40 through 66 speak of a bright future when Messiah comes and establishes His kingdom.
3. Isaiah is the longest of the prophetic books. It is one of what are called the major prophets, not because of necessarily importance, but because of length. For this reason, we will summarize the book by looking at some key verses.

B. Chapter 1 presents Judah as an utterly corrupt nation: “Ah, sinful nation, a people laden with iniquity, offspring of evildoers, children who deal corruptly! They have forsaken the LORD, they have despised the Holy One of Israel, they are utterly estranged” (Vs. 1:4).

C. Chapter 2 gives a preview of what will be promised in chapters 40 through 66. “It shall come to pass in the latter days that the mountain of the house of the LORD shall be established as the highest of the mountains, and shall be lifted up above the hills; and all the nations shall flow to it, and many peoples shall come, and say: “‘Come, let us go up to the mountain of the LORD, to the house of the God of Jacob, that he may teach us his ways and that we may walk in his paths’” (Vs. 2:2-3). Also: “It shall come to pass in the latter days that the mountain of the house of the LORD shall be established as the highest of the mountains, and shall be lifted up above the hills; and all the nations shall flow to it, and many peoples shall come, and say: “‘Come, let us go up to the mountain of the LORD, to the house of the God of Jacob, that he may teach us his ways and that we may walk in his paths’” (Vs. 2:4).

D. Chapter 6. Isaiah has a vision of God on His throne. He responds to God’s call: “‘And I heard the voice of the Lord saying, “‘Whom shall I send, and who will go for us?’” Then I said, “Here I am! Send me”” (Vs. 6:8).

E. Chapter 7. Isaiah is sent by the Lord to King Ahaz. The king is troubled about word that Syria and Israel will attack him. Isaiah is told to tell him that their plans will “not stand and it will not come to pass” (Vs. 7:7). The Lord tells Ahaz to ask of him a sign, but Ahaz is afraid to do so. The Lord then gives him a sign: “Therefore the Lord himself will give you a sign. Behold, the virgin shall conceive and bear a son, and shall call his name Immanuel” (Vs. 7:14). This is a prophecy of Christ’s birth. Bible critics point out that the word “virgin: in Hebrew is “almah” which could mean virgin or just a young maiden of child-bearing age. This could leave some room for doubt. But when the Septuagint was translated from the Hebrew to the Greek in the third century BC, the Hebrew scholars used the specific Greek word for virgin which is “Parthenos”. However, the best proof that Isaiah meant “virgin” is that birth of a child by a young maiden in itself would not be “a sign”. That the birth of Jesus to the virgin Mary was a miracle, and was definitely a sign. The virgin birth is a cornerstone of the tenets of the Christian faith.

F. Chapter 9 contains the most powerful verse pertaining to the Trinity in Bible: “For to us a child is born, to us a son is given; and the government shall be upon his shoulder, and his name shall be called Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God,

Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace” (Vs. 9:6). In this passage, you have Jesus (child, son, Prince of Peace). You have the Holy Spirit (Wonderful Counselor) and God (Mighty God, Everlasting Father). You also have a prophecy of His coming kingdom (the government shall be upon his shoulder).

G. Chapter 11 opens with a prophecy of the coming Messiah: “There shall come forth a shoot from the stump of Jesse, and a branch from his roots shall bear fruit. And the Spirit of the LORD shall rest upon him, the Spirit of wisdom and understanding, the Spirit of counsel and might, the Spirit of knowledge and the fear of the LORD” (Vs. 11:1-2). Many scholars link this passage with the book of Revelation where the seven spirits of God are mentioned: (1:4-5; 3:1; 4:5 and 5:6).

H. Chapter 12 is an affirmation of the strength of the Lord and a song of praise: “Behold, God is my salvation; I will trust, and will not be afraid; for the LORD GOD is my strength and my song, and he has become my salvation” (Vs. 12:2).

I. Chapter 14 includes a prophecy against Satan: “How you are fallen from heaven, O Day Star, son of Dawn! How you are cut down to the ground, you who laid the nations low! You said in your heart, ‘I will ascend to heaven; above the stars of God, I will set my throne on high; I will sit on the mount of assembly in the far reaches of the north; I will ascend above the heights of the clouds; I will make myself like the Most High.’ But you are brought down to Sheol, to the far reaches of the pit” (Vs. 14:12-15).

J. In chapter 26, some see a hint of the rapture of the church before the wrath of God is poured out during the Tribulation: “Come, my people, enter your chambers, and shut your doors behind you; hide yourselves for a little while until the fury has passed by. For behold, the LORD is coming out from his place to punish the inhabitants of the earth for their iniquity, and the earth will disclose the blood shed on it, and will no more cover its slain” (Vs. 26:20-21).

K. Chapter 35 is a prophecy of the redeemed returning to the land under the lordship of the Messiah: “And the ransomed of the LORD shall return and come to Zion with singing; everlasting joy shall be upon their heads; they shall obtain gladness and joy, and sorrow and sighing shall flee away” (Vs. 35:10).

L. Chapters 36 and 37 recount the king of Assyria, Sennacherib’s conquest of Samaria and most of Judah. His messengers taunt the servants of King Hezekiah. Assyria has previously destroyed all the other cities of Samaria and Judah. Hezekiah

takes the written message from Sennacherib and spreads it before the Lord in the temple. He cries out to the Lord in a plea to save Jerusalem (Vs. 37:14-20). The Lord hears his prayer and says: “Therefore thus says the LORD concerning the king of Assyria: ‘He shall not come into this city or shoot an arrow there or come before it with a shield or cast up a siege mound against it. By the way that he came, by the same he shall return, and he shall not come into this city, declares the LORD. For I will defend this city to save it, for my own sake and for the sake of my servant David” (Vs. 37:33-35). Sennacherib’s army of 185,000 is destroyed by an angel of the Lord and he returns to Nineveh where he is assassinated by two of his sons (Vs. 37:36-38).

M. Chapter 38 is an account of Hezekiah’s sickness and his prayer to the Lord. The Lord promises to give him 15 more years of life, and the sign to confirm this promise is having the shadow of the sun go back ten steps (Vs. 38:1-8).

N. Chapter 39 recounts how the king of Babylon sent envoys to Hezekiah as he had heard that he was sick. Hezekiah receives them, but shows them all the riches of his treasure house and storehouses. Isaiah finds out about it and tells Hezekiah that all of that will be taken to Babylon, including his sons. Hezekiah is content that none of that would happen in his lifetime.

O. Chapter 40 begins the second section of the book pointing to the complete restoration of Israel and Judah under the Messiah: “A voice cries: ‘In the wilderness prepare the way of the LORD; make straight in the desert a highway for our God. Every valley shall be lifted up, and every mountain and hill be made low; the uneven ground shall become level, and the rough places a plain. And the glory of the LORD shall be revealed, and all flesh shall see it together, for the mouth of the LORD has spoken’” (Vs. 40:3-5).

P. Chapter 44 affirms that there is no God but the Lord: “Thus says the LORD, the King of Israel and his Redeemer, the LORD of hosts: ‘I am the first and I am the last; besides me there is no god’” (Vs. 44:6). The chapter also addresses the folly of idolatry (Vs. 44:9-20).

Q. Chapter 45 includes one of the most profound prophecies in Scripture. It names the conqueror of Babylon, King Cyrus, and calls him “His anointed”. It describes how Babylon will be taken (Vs. 45:1-6). This was written by Isaiah about 150 years before the prophecy was fulfilled. It is one of the reasons that skeptics proposed the Deutero-Isaiah theory due to its precision.

R. Chapter 46 affirms God's sovereignty and that He exists outside the realm and limitations of time and space: "'remember the former things of old; for I am God, and there is no other; I am God, and there is none like me, declaring the end from the beginning and from ancient times things not yet done, saying, 'My counsel shall stand, and I will accomplish all my purpose'" (Vs. 46:9-10).

S. Chapter 53 contains the prophetic word of the suffering Messiah, Jesus, upon whom our sins were laid: "Surely, he has borne our griefs and carried our sorrows; yet we esteemed him stricken, smitten by God, and afflicted. But he was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities; upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace, and with his wounds we are healed. All we like sheep have gone astray; we have turned—every one—to his own way; and the LORD has laid on him the iniquity of us all" (Vs. 53:4-6).

T. Chapter 55 includes an exhortation to seek the Lord: "Seek the LORD while he may be found; call upon him while he is near; let the wicked forsake his way, and the unrighteous man his thoughts; let him return to the LORD, that he may have compassion on him, and to our God, for he will abundantly pardon. For my thoughts are not your thoughts, neither are your ways my ways, declares the LORD. For as the heavens are higher than the earth, so are my ways higher than your ways and my thoughts than your thoughts" (Vs. 55:6-9).

U. Chapter 61 opens with the passage that Jesus partially read from the scroll of Isaiah in the synagogue in His hometown (Luke 4:18-19). Here is the complete passage as it appears in verses Isaiah 61:1-2: "The Spirit of the Lord GOD is upon me, because the LORD has anointed me to bring good news to the poor; he has sent me to bind up the brokenhearted, to proclaim liberty to the captives, and the opening of the prison to those who are bound; to proclaim the year of the LORD's favor, and the day of vengeance of our God; to comfort all who mourn". Jesus stopped after "the year of the Lord's favor" and did not read "and the day of vengeance of our God". Jesus then rolled up the scroll, handed it to the attendant and sat down. He then said: "today, this Scripture has been fulfilled in your hearing" (Vs. Luke 4:21b). Jesus was declaring that He was the long-awaited Messiah, but his mission at His first coming was not to execute "the day of vengeance of our God". He went on to speak, and initially, the response was favorable. But as he continued to speak about God sending Eliha to a gentile widow and Naaman the Syrian being healed of leprosy, they became enraged and attempted to throw Him off the cliff that their town was built upon (Vs. Luke 4:22-30).

V. Chapter 62 includes affirmation that Jerusalem will be a light to the nations and salvation in the Messiah: “Behold, the LORD has proclaimed to the end of the earth: Say to the daughter of Zion, ‘Behold, your salvation comes; behold, his reward is with him, and his recompense before him.’ And they shall be called The Holy People, The Redeemed of the LORD; and you shall be called Sought Out, A City Not Forsaken” (Vs. 62:11-12).

W. Chapter 63 foretells the vengeance of God in Christ upon His return: “Who is this who comes from Edom, in crimsoned garments from Bozrah, he who is splendid in his apparel, marching in the greatness of his strength? ‘It is I, speaking in righteousness, mighty to save’” And also: “‘For the day of vengeance was in my heart, and my year of redemption had come’” (Vs. 63:1;4).

X. Chapter 65 is a description of the eternal kingdom of Christ and links with Revelation chapter 21: “For behold, I create new heavens and a new earth, and the former things shall not be remembered or come into mind (Vs. 65:17).

Y. Chapter 66 closes the book of Isaiah with words about the final judgement and glory of the Lord. It also hints of the restoration of Israel as a nation in one day on May 14, 1948: Who has heard such a thing? Who has seen such things? Shall a land be born in one day? Shall a nation be brought forth in one moment?” (Vs. 66:8a).

Z. Discussion Questions, Application and Passing it on.

1. Are you able to use what you have learned in this lesson to counter any arguments you may hear about the Deutero-Isaiah theory?
2. The virgin birth and the Trinity are crucial to the understanding of the foundational doctrines of the Christian faith. From this lesson, are you able to use the information given to defend these doctrines?
3. Archeological excavations have found what is called the “Assyrian destruction layer” in every Location of a biblical town in existence at the time of King Hezekiah except for Jerusalem. That is due to the Lord’s promise to spare Jerusalem from destruction at that time for his “servant David”. Does this promise and the dramatic evidence to that, increase your faith in God’s other promises?
4. Can you present the gospel to a Jew or another unbeliever using Isaiah chapter 53?
5. Why is the wrath of God important in presenting the gospel?

6. Are you able to use the prophecies in Chapters 45 and 53 to present the gospel?

This Old Testament survey was provided by Joshua Nations (JoshuaNations.org)

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In Christ,

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